During the preceding century, a revolution in thinking which would prove fundamental to humanity had taken place in Miletus. A group of thinkers had reformulated the way questions were asked about the world, and the way answers were sought. The greatest of these thinkers was Anaximander.

From time immemorial, or at least since humanity had left written texts which have come down to us, men had asked themselves how the world had come into being, what it was composed of, how it was ordered, and why natural phenomena occurred. For thousands of years they had given themselves answers which all resembled one another: answers which referred to elaborate stories of spirits, deities, imaginary and mythological creatures, and other similar things. From cuneiform tablets to ancient Chinese texts; from hieroglyphic writing in the Pyramids to the myths of the Sioux; from the most ancient Indian texts to the Bible; from African stories to those of aboriginal Australians, it was all a colourful but basically quite monotonous flow – of Plumed Serpents and Great Cows, of irascible, litigious, or kindly deities who create the world by breathing over abysses, uttering '*Fiat lux*', or emerging out of a stone egg.

Then, at Miletus, at the beginning of the fifth century before our era, Thales, his pupil Anaximander, Hecataeus and their school find a different way of looking for answers. This immense revolution in thought inaugurates a new mode of knowledge and understanding, and signals the first dawn of scientific thought.

The Milesians understand that by shrewdly using observation and reason, rather than searching for answers in fantasy, ancient myths or religion – and, above all, by using critical thought in a discriminating way – it is possible to repeatedly correct our world view, and to discover new aspects of reality which are hidden to the common view. It is possible to discover the new.

Perhaps the decisive discovery is that of a different style of thinking, where the disciple is no longer obliged to respect and share the ideas of the master but is free to build on those ideas without being afraid to discard or criticize the part that can be improved. This is a novel middle way, placed between full adherence to a school and generic deprecation of ideas. It is the key to the subsequent development of philosophical and scientific thinking: from this moment onwards, knowledge begins to grow at a vertiginous pace, nourished by past knowledge but at the same time by the possibility of criticism, and therefore of improving knowledge and understanding. The dazzling *incipit* of Hecataeus's book of history goes to the heart of this critical thinking, including as it does the awareness of our own fallibility: 'I wrote things which seem true to me, because the accounts of the Greeks seem to be full of contradictory and ridiculous things.'

According to legend, Heracles descended to Hades from Cape Tenaro. Hecataeus visits Cape Tenaro, and determines that there is in fact no